

USMLE → ECFMG Certification → Residency Match

A Step-by-Step Pathway for International Medical Graduates (IMGs)

Beyond Medical School (BMS)

The USMLE Pathway at a Glance

Medical school preparation → Establish MyIntealth Identity

Apply for ECFMG Certification → Register and pass Step 1 and 2 CK

Build a competitive IMG profile → ECFMG Certification

ERAS residency application → Interviews

NRMP Rank Order List → Match Day

Begin U.S. residency training

Note: These activities can overlap. Certification and program deadlines differ.

1–3. Medical School → MyIntealth

1. Medical School

Advisable: consider taking the USMLE Steps after the first clinical year, when foundational and clinical knowledge are sufficiently developed.

Timing can vary depending on learning pace, curriculum and clinical exposure.

2. Proof of education

Current student: School must confirm your current enrollment and eligibility through the required process. Eg. Dean's Letter / appropriate school documentation.

Graduate: Medical School Certificate or letter of attestation if the certificate is not yet ready.

ECFMG obtains primary-source verification from the school.

Note: Contact your school early about documentation, response times and any local fees.

3. Create a MyIntealth account

Approx. \$110* account-establishment fee

Prepare personal information, medical school information, current unexpired passport and recent digital photograph.

4–6. Identification, ECFMG Application & Verification

4. Complete the Intealth Identification Form (IIF)

Complete the online notarization/identity process. The notarization fee is included in the account-establishment fee in the figures provided.

5. Apply for ECFMG Certification

Approx. \$580* application fee.

Provide medical school, attendance and graduation/degree information.

Medical school must be listed in the World Directory of Medical Schools (WDOMS).

ECFMG requires Primary Source Verification of credentials through the medical school.

Credential verification: approx. \$220* total (\$110* per document in the figures provided).

Contact the Dean's/medical school office early; the school may charge its own administrative fee.

4–6. Identification, ECFMG Application & Verification

6. ECFMG reviews and accepts the application. Applicants must meet the credential-verification requirements.

7-9. USMLE Step 1, Step 2 CK & STEP 3

IMGs register for all three Step exams through FSMB, following the January 2026 service transition. Schedule with Prometric after receiving a permit.

Registration is through the current USMLE registration process; verify the responsible registration organization and fees before payment.

7. Register for Step 1: Figures provided: \$695* + \$210* international testing-region fee(testing outside the US and Canada)

Scored as Pass/Fail.

Use official USMLE sample materials and appropriate learning resources. Common preparation resource: UWorld, AMBOSS, ANKI Flashcards, First Aid, Boards & Beyond, NBME Self-Assessments.

7-9. USMLE Step 1, Step 2 CK & STEP 3

8. Step 2 CK

Clinical knowledge examination; unlike Step 1, Step 2 CK is scored numerically.

The minimum passing score can change. Check the current USMLE policy before planning.

For residency applications, a strong Step 2 CK performance may be important because programs can use it as part of their holistic review.

9. Step 3

It is part of the USMLE pathway, but it is generally not a requirement you need to complete before applying/matching into residency.

Testing is only in the US and its territories. Fee \$955.

Note: Do you have to write Step 3?

If your goal is ultimately to become independently licensed to practice medicine in the U.S. Then, yes, Step 3 is an important part of the licensing pathway.

But you do not normally need Step 3 to obtain ECFMG Certification or to enter the Match.

10–12. Build Your IMG Profile & Obtain Certification

10. Build your IMG profile

Research projects, publications and presentations.

U.S. clinical experience where eligible: observerships, clinical rotations and other supervised experiences.

Leadership, volunteering, teaching, awards and other meaningful experiences.

Check eligibility before arranging US clinical experiences.

11. OET(occupational English Test) Medicine

All Pathways applicants need OET Medicine, regardless of native language or medical-school teaching language

OET minimums in one sitting: Listening 350, Reading 350, Speaking 350 and Writing 300. For 2027 Pathways, test on or after 1 January 2025.

10–12. Build Your IMG Profile & Obtain Certification

12. ECFMG Certification

Complete the applicable examination, credential-verification and other certification requirements.

Step 1 + Step 2 CK form the USMLE examination component of the pathway. OET forms the clinical/communication component

Timing matters: plan certification early enough for the residency application and Match cycle.

13–16. Residency Application: ERAS

13. Prepare your residency application through ERAS. Obtain an ERAS token through MyIntealth (\$185)

14. Typical application components

- CV/application information and medical school transcript.

- Dean's Letter / MSPE and USMLE scores.

- Personal Statement.

- Letters of Recommendation (often including U.S. clinical supervisors when available).

- Research, publications, experiences, volunteer activities and achievements.

15. Choose specialty and programs

- Check each program's IMG eligibility, specialty requirements, exam requirements and deadlines.

16. Submit ERAS applications: Programs review applications and may invite applicants for interviews.

Residency Interviews: Questions to Prepare For

Tell me about yourself.

Why did you choose this specialty?

Why are you interested in our program?

Why do you want to train in the United States?

Why should we select you for our residency program?

Tell me about a difficult clinical situation and how you handled it.

Tell me about a clinical mistake or failure and what you learned from it.

Describe a time you had a disagreement with a colleague or supervisor.

How do you manage stress and maintain your performance?

What are your career goals after residency?

What research or academic interests do you have?

How would you contribute to our program and the wider community?

17–20. Interview → Rank List → Match → Residency

17. Residency Interviews

Interview with programs that invite you.

Use interviews to understand training, culture, rotations, mentorship, research and resident support.

18. Rank Order List (ROL)

Rank the programs you interviewed with according to your own preferences. Rank only programs where you are willing to train. A Match commitment is binding under NRMP rules

Programs submit their own rank lists.

The NRMP matching algorithm processes applicant and program preferences.

19. Match Day

Find out whether you matched and, if matched, the program where you will begin residency training.

Matching does not guarantee your first choice.

20. Begin Residency

Complete onboarding, licensing/credentialing and start residency training.

Planning the Timeline

Early medical school: Learn about the U.S. pathway and identify long-term goals.

Clinical years: Build foundational/clinical knowledge and plan Step 1/Step 2 CK timing.

Before exams: Confirm eligibility, documentation, registration and testing requirements.

Before Match season: Complete certification requirements early enough for your target application cycle.

Application season: ERAS submission → program review → interviews.

After interviews: Submit NRMP Rank Order List → Match Day → residency onboarding.

Fee Legend & Important Note

* Fees are approximate figures provided for educational planning purposes and are subject to change.

Always verify the current fee directly with the relevant official organization before making payment.

Additional costs may include medical school administrative fees, document/courier charges, exam preparation resources, travel, accommodation, visa expenses and U.S. clinical experience costs.

Budget for the entire pathway—not just examination fees.

2027 residency application and Match dates

Date	Milestone
2 September 2026	ERAS application submission opens
15 September 2026	NRMP registration opens
23 September 2026	Programs begin reviewing ERAS applications
31 January 2027	2027 Pathways application deadline (ET)
3 March 2027, 9 p.m. ET	NRMP rank-list certification deadline
15 March 2027	Match status released / Match Week begins
19 March 2027	Match Day: program placement released

September 23 starts program review; it is not a universal application deadline.

Check individual program deadlines and Pathways documentation deadlines.

Full ECFMG certification is required before residency training.

Current fees and budget planning

Item	Fee (USD)
MyIntealth account / ECFMG application / verification	\$110 / \$580 / \$220
Step 1 outside US and Canada	\$695 + \$210 = \$905
Step 2 CK outside US and Canada	\$695 + \$235 = \$930
2027 Pathways application / ERAS token	\$945 / \$185
ERAS applications, per specialty	\$11 each for programs 1–30, then \$30 each
USMLE transcript / NRMP standard registration	\$70 per season / \$85
Step 3 (when taken)	\$955

Also budget for OET, preparation, school/translation charges, USCE, travel, accommodation and visas. Retakes and late or additional services cost extra.

Fees are current at verification and may change. Confirm before payment.

Key Takeaway

Start planning early.

Know the eligibility and documentation requirements before paying fees.

Prepare strategically for Step 1 and Step 2 CK.

Build a well-rounded IMG profile—not only exam scores.

Research programs carefully and track deadlines.

Use interviews to communicate your experiences, goals and fit with the program.

Keep checking official USMLE, ECFMG/Intealth, ERAS and NRMP guidance because requirements and fees can change.

Official resources: [USMLE.org](https://www.usmle.org), [ECFMG.org](https://www.ecfm.org), [FSMB.org](https://www.fsmb.org), [AAMC.org](https://www.aamc.org) and [NRMP.org](https://www.nrmp.org).